

STAGE FIVE • THINKING, REASONING & MENTAL MODELS

FIRSTS

FACILITATOR NOTES / SCRIPT

Suggested language for openings, transitions, and prompting discussion

A Citrus Edition Facilitator Resource • Companion to the FIRSTS Manual

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FIRSTS • Facilitator Notes / Script

Stage Five • Thinking, Reasoning & Mental Models

HOW TO USE THIS SCRIPT

This document is written for a first-time or less confident facilitator who wants actual suggested language, not just a topic list. Everything in quotes is meant to be read close to verbatim, or adapted lightly into your own voice.

Stage Five's biggest facilitation challenge is abstraction — it's easy for a framework discussion to stay theoretical and forgettable. Much of this script is aimed specifically at pulling participants back to real, concrete, personal examples whenever the conversation drifts abstract.

It's organized into four parts: session openings, transitions between FIRSTS, discussion prompting for five situations that come up often in this stage, and tricky moments flagged at specific FIRSTS where participants commonly get stuck or resistant.

Part 1 — Session Openings

Opening Session 1

“Welcome to Stage Five. This stage is a bit different from what's come before — we're not asking who you are, we're building tools for how you think. Every FIRST here is a specific reasoning technique you'll apply to something real in your own life.”

“A quick note: this stage rewards specificity. ‘I used the decision matrix on a general kind of choice’ won't get you much. ‘I used it on whether to take this specific internship or that specific one’ will. Bring real problems, not hypothetical ones.”

Opening Session 2

“Last session gave you eight individual tools. Today is less about adding new tools and more about integration — catching your own biases, seeing systems instead of isolated failures, and reflecting honestly on your own patterns.”

Opening Session 3

“We're moving into more advanced territory today. These frameworks assume the foundational ones from the first two sessions and apply them to bigger, more complex, higher-stakes decisions.”

“This is our longest session. We'll take an extra short break partway through — don't hesitate to say something if you need a moment even outside the scheduled breaks.”

Opening Session 4 (Stage Close)

“Our final session for Stage Five is about making reasoning repeatable and sustained — checklists, feedback loops, and a strategic map that ties this whole stage together.”

Part 2 — Transitions Between FIRSTS

A few sentences said out loud between exercises and between sessions turns a checklist of frameworks into a coherent, cumulative narrative.

FIRST G1 → G2

“Now that you can name a mental model you already use, let's practice a specific one: tracing an outcome back to its real cause, not just the first one that comes to mind.”

FIRST G5 → G6

“We just looked at root causes within a specific problem. Critical thinking zooms out to a broader habit: questioning the assumptions underneath any claim, not just problems you're trying to fix.”

Session 1 → Session 2

“You now have eight tools. Today isn't about adding more — it's about turning them inward: catching your own biases, seeing the systems you're part of, and reflecting honestly on your own decision patterns.”

FIRST G12 → G13

“You've just prioritized a real task list. Now let's make sure you can actually apply one of these models rigorously, in writing, not just informally in your head.”

Session 2 → Session 3

“Everything so far has been foundational. Today we scale up — these are the frameworks for genuinely complex decisions with real stakes.”

FIRST H18 → H19

“Inversion asked what would guarantee failure. Opportunity cost asks a related question: what are you actually giving up by choosing this path instead of another?”

FIRST H20 → H21

“You just looked at where your own effort actually pays off. Now let's take systems thinking, which you practiced individually in Session 2, and apply it to a real team or project.”

Session 3 → Session 4

“You now have frameworks for big, complex decisions. This final session is about the smaller, sustained habits, checklists, feedback loops, and strategic maps, that keep good reasoning going day to day.”

FIRST H25 → H26

“A root cause framework helps you dig deep once. A feedback loop is about doing that kind of learning repeatedly, as an ongoing habit rather than a single dig.”

FIRST H29 → H30

“You just tested one specific assumption at small scale. Strategic mapping zooms all the way out: does your daily action actually connect to where you're trying to go long-term?”

Part 3 — Prompting Discussion in the Moment

Five situations that come up often in this specific stage, with suggested language for each.

A participant's example stays abstract or hypothetical

"Let's ground this in something real. What's an actual decision you're facing this week, even a small one, we could run through this framework together?"

Someone struggles to find their own root cause and keeps landing on symptoms

"Keep asking why one more time. If the answer feels a little uncomfortable or surprising, that's often a sign you're getting closer to the real one."

A participant resists the Cognitive Bias Audit ("I don't think I'm that biased")

"That's actually the most common bias of all — believing your own reasoning is unusually objective. Let's try it on one specific, real decision rather than in the abstract."

The room feels fatigued during a dense, framework-heavy stretch (especially Session 3)

"Let's pause for a second. Instead of the next framework, tell the person next to you about one thing from today that's already changed how you're thinking about something real."

Someone finishes early and seems unsure what to do with extra time

"Go back to an earlier FIRST this session and apply it to a second, different real problem. The framework gets sharper with repetition, not just explanation."

Part 4 — Tricky Moments by FIRST

Four specific FIRSTS where participants commonly get stuck, resistant, or stay too abstract — and language to navigate each moment.

FIRST G9

Cognitive Bias Audit

FACILITATOR NOTE

Self-assessment of one's own bias is genuinely hard, and some participants will produce a shallow or defensive answer. If time allows, pair this with the group adaptation (Outside Mirror) from the Group Versions document, since outside perspective catches what solo reflection often misses.

FIRST G15

Reflection on Decision-Making

FACILITATOR NOTE

Watch for participants who only journal about decisions that went well. Gently and specifically ask about a recent decision that didn't go as planned — the honest, uncomfortable examples are where the real learning tends to live.

FIRST H17

First-Principles Analysis

FACILITATOR NOTE

Some participants confuse this with simply being contrarian or dismissive of convention. Redirect firmly: the goal is genuine verification of what's actually required, not rejecting precedent for its own sake.

FIRST H21

Systems Thinking Application

FACILITATOR NOTE

When mapping a real team problem gets genuinely difficult, there's a strong pull to default back to blaming a specific person. Name this pull explicitly and encourage pushing through to the structural cause instead.